

ADVENTURE HOOK

While the characters are in the city of Phlan or traveling nearby, they encounter this handbill posted on a wall or tree. They could also hear the information directly in conversation with a traveling merchant or a resident of Phlan or overhear other travelers discussing "the undead problem" at Valhingen Graveyard.

WANTED:
Holy Knights,
Blessed Warriors of the Gods,
and other bold slayers of the Undead.
Reward commensurate with risk.
For particulars, contact Doomguide Yovir Glandon
at Valhingen Graveyard, City of Phlan

VALHINGEN GRAVEYARD

The graveyard sits north of the city, on the opposite shore of Stojanow River. It is a beautiful garden of statues, tended plants, trees, mausoleums, and headstones. The condition of the graveyard is entirely pristine thanks to the tireless work of Kelemvorites who tend it.

Phlan has been the site of a city for over 1,000 years. It's experienced so many cycles of growth and collapse, of prosperity and destruction, that it's impossible to estimate accurately how many people have lived there and subsequently been interred in Valhingen. A conservative estimate puts the number at well over 100,000 but that estimate could easily be two, three, or even five times that many.

Valhingen is large, but so many bodies couldn't possibly be buried there in individual graves and family mausoleums. Most of them are interred in catacombs beneath the graveyard. The catacombs are nearly as old as the city, and their full extent is unknown even to the most senior of Kelemvorites. They extend well beyond the boundary of the graveyard in every direction, including under the city.

Several of the major temples and fortifications in Phlan were known to have entrances of their own, but most of these were sealed during times when undead were a threat. If any of them remain open, no one living in Phlan today knows of them. The only entrance that's known to still be open is the Cloister of Kelemvor in Valhingen Graveyard, and only those galleries directly connected to it are still used for burials.

THE CITY OF PHLAN

The bulk of the action in *Dues for the Dead* takes place under Valhingen Graveyard. Characters might spend a short time in the city proper, however, when they first arrive or if they consult with a sage during the adventure. In that case, you'll want some basic, atmospheric information on the city.

Phlan has a thousand-year history of ascendance and collapse. Currently, it's experiencing tough times. Less than a year ago, the city's Lord Protector Anivar Daoran was killed in an apparent construction accident while inspecting renovations at Valjevo Castle. Daoran wasn't much of a Lord Protector and he isn't widely mourned. Because he left no heir, the Knight Commander of the Black Fist, Ector Brahms, was declared the Lord Regent. Brahms is an honorable but hidebound man, and Phlan has declined tragically under his guidance. Soldiers of the Black Fist rule the city by martial law. They swiftly dispense punishment but seldom justice. Their increasingly harsh methods are failing to preserve law or order.

Without the Black Fist to protect them, the people have turned to two other sources; the city's guilds (chiefly stonewrights, carpenters, ironhands, and merchants) and a criminal organization called the Welcomers. These six organizations are constantly at odds with one another over power in the city and, aside from limited exceptions among the guilds, are completely unable to cooperate for the betterment of Phlan. Lord Protector Daoran had begun many construction projects around the city, renovating ancient buildings and reconstructing those damaged in recent wars. All of that work is halted since the city has no money to pay the guilds for their labor; half-built structures are everywhere and heaps of unused construction material clog the streets.

Trade, too, has come to a standstill, leaving merchants with few legal ways to make a living. The Welcomers are openly criminal, and the once-honest guilds are only a few steps removed from being organized crime syndicates themselves. The Black Fist's methods have made it the people's enemy instead of their guardian, so most honest folk have retreated into the ranks of the Welcomers and the guilds for survival.

PART 1: VALHINGEN

GRAVEYARD

The graveyard is the only notable feature of Phlan that sits north of the river. Most of the city is on what's presumed to be an artificial island; sometime in the dim past, Phlan's original builders dug a canal to split the Stojanow River into two channels at its mouth, with the two branches flowing around the city like a moat. A bridge near the city's North Gate crosses the river a short distance west of the graveyard, so mourners can walk to the cemetery easily.

The cemetery itself is quite beautiful.

Valhingen Graveyard looks more like a park than a cemetery and stands in stark contrast to the ramshackle, half-built Phlan. Gravel walkways wend between tall trees, well-tended beds of shrubs and flowers, sturdy mausoleums, and rows of headstones, monuments, and commemorative statues.

You need only a few moments to spot a man and a woman dressed in simple, home-spun gray robes trimming shrubs and pulling weeds from between gravestones.

The man and woman are clerics of Kelemvor named **Drolo** and **Fedya**. They are happy to talk about their work in the cemetery, but they grow morose if asked about undead. Instead, they direct characters to a small chapel where Doomguide Yovir Glandon can be found.

KELEMVOR'S FAITHFUL

Doomguide is the title adopted by heads of clerical chapters among the faithful of Kelemvor, Faerûn's deity of death and the dead. "Doom" refers not to a bleak destiny but simply to the fact that all mortals face an end to life. Kelemvor's servants ensure that the dead are properly interred and respected, and they see to the needs of the bereaved. To most of Kelemvor's faithful, raising a dead person as an undead creature is the most horrific sacrilege imaginable and an unforgivable violation of human sanctity.

THE DOOMGUIDE'S TALE

Finding Doomguide Glandon is simple enough. Yovir Glandon is a human male of middle age, humorless and stoic in his duty among the dead.

Doomguide Yovir Glandon is a thin, human male of middle age, with a shaved head and a well-trimmed beard, streaked with grey. He is dressed in a grass-stained gray robe with twigs and leaves tangled around the frayed hem, sweeping leaves out of the simple stone chapel with a worn-out broom.

As you approach, he stops sweeping and turns his deep-set, blue eyes in your direction.

"Hello there," he says in a surprisingly resonant voice, "What service can Kelemvor's Faithful provide for you today?"

ROLEPLAYING DOOMGUIDE GLANDON

Yovir Glandon has toiled in the gardens of Valhingen for nearly 40 years. But despite his dirty, calloused hands and his grass-stained robes, he is a learned man. Yovir is a reserved man, who lets others steer the course of a conversation; interjecting only where necessary.

Yovir prefers to let characters bring up the subject of the handbill or rumors of undead themselves, rather than asking them if they're mercenaries looking for work (that fact should be obvious to anyone who glances at the heavily armed and armored characters). Once asked, he relates the following tale. During the course of their conversation, Yovir provides the following information:

- Some of the adventurers may know Doomguide Yovir from DDEX1-3 *Shadows over the Moonsea*. If this is the case, Yovir is especially pleased to see them again.
- Within the last 100 years, Valhingen Graveyard has gone from being overrun with undead to the statuesque place of rest it is today. This is due primarily to the work of the Kelemvorites.
- To the people of Phlan, the idyllic beauty of Valhingen is their reward for the trials they have faced during their hard life when it is over.
- A novice Kelemvorite disappeared about a month ago. Yovir was initially unconcerned as the life of a Kelemvorite is difficult, and those who cannot accommodate it simply leave.
- Suspicions were aroused when Brother Rasoran—another Kelemvorite—vanished. It was not possible that he would leave; he has been dedicated to the faith and to the people of Phlan for nearly 10 years.
- Sister Bethel disappeared and was subsequently located twelve days ago; partially eaten.
- Yovir believes that undead are active once more within Valhingen.
- Yovir and a few other Kelemvorites investigated the oldest section of the known catacombs and found no undead. It was sealed to prevent them spreading

inside.

If the adventurers appear interested in taking the job, Yovir provides the following information.

- He can pay the characters 100 gp and a set of *goggles of night*.
- If the adventurers ask for an advance to pay for supplies, he instead gives them the *goggles of night*.
- Yovir asks that the adventurers do not disturb the resting dead within the catacombs and to leave their possessions be. Theft from the dead is not tolerated.
- The catacombs are extensive, and Yovir offers the adventurers the services of a guide if they so desire one.

If the adventurers accept Yovir's offer of a guide, Yovir calls out "Cassyt!", and a young woman named Cassyt shuffles into the room. She is a plain-looking female half-elf who appears to be in her early twenties. She uses the **acolyte** stat block. Besides acting as guide, Cassyt also carries a lantern to help light the tunnels, unless characters prefer darkness. Cassyt knows as much of the history of the catacombs as you want him or her to tell the characters.

Cassyt assist the party using cantrips when able to do so from range, but flees if confronted by an enemy. She does not use her first level spell slots until the final encounter in Area 14b.

ROLEPLAYING CASSYT

Cassyt is a young Kelemvorite who has spent more time in her books than in the catacombs of the graveyard. Despite this, she has an unusually sunny disposition and is prone to chatter incessantly rattling off minutiae and trivia about the catacombs. She knows quite a bit about Sections 1 through 3 of the catacombs (History +4; catacombs only) and first aid (Medicine +3). She also has a dry, albeit slightly warped, sense of humor.

TREASURE

If they ask, the adventurers are given a pair of *goggles of night* to assist them with their excursion.

PART 2: THE UPPER

CATACOMBS

The entrance to the catacombs is through a stone structure that resembles the many mausoleums in the graveyard, except this building has no door, just an open archway. Inside is a small paved floor that opens into a wide stone staircase. The building is little more than a covering over the stairs. Dwarves can easily see that the stone building is much newer than the steps; the walls and roof have stood for no more than two centuries, but the steps are at least four times that old; possibly even older.

GENERAL FEATURES

Note that the map is labeled with north at the bottom and south at the top. This is so you can more easily draw it correctly for the players without needing to continually flip it upside down.

Ceilings and Walls. Although the catacombs are all excavated from earth and solid stone, the tunnels look nothing like a mine. Most walls and ceilings are either faced with smooth stone or have decorative features such as faux pillars, ledges, geometric designs, and scenes of life or religious themes carved into the stone. Unless otherwise specified, the ceilings of the catacombs are only 10 feet high.

Crypts. Most individual crypts are not described, because they're all basically the same. The walls are carved with loculi (niches) that contain either a single body or the stacked bones of many bodies. Most of these crypts aren't very interesting; they contain no treasure, no monsters, and no clues. Most of the bodies in a particular crypt are related somehow. Usually they're of the same family, but customs changed over the centuries: some crypts contain members of the same guild, or people of the same age, or people who died of the same causes or who served in the same military units. Characters should be less interested in what's inside individual crypts than by what's happening in the tunnels around them.

Light. The catacombs are completely dark except where noted. Niches are carved into the walls every 20 feet for placement of oil lamps, but lamps aren't left in the niches. The faithful of Kelemvor bring lamps with them when they come into the catacombs. In a few places, open shafts have been dug from the catacombs to the surface to let in air and light. These are noted in

text and on the map.

Sound. The catacombs deaden sound effectively. For lack of a better phrase, the catacombs are, for the most part, as silent as the grave. Occasionally, dripping water can be heard. Open shafts for letting in air and light sometimes produce unsettling akin moaning or whistling on windy days. It is not unheard of to hear distant crying while in the catacombs, but it is attributed to those on in the graveyard, above, mourning their dead instead of any malevolence within the catacombs.

Undead. The faithful of Kelemvor cleared all the undead out of these catacombs decades ago and kept the tunnels clear since then. However, due to the sheer size of the catacombs, the Red Wizard Rorreth Monforoth has had plenty of time to animate undead creatures from the crypts before their presence was prematurely discovered. Monforoth can't control all the undead he created, and some of them strayed into areas of the catacombs that allowed their discovery

Water. Most of the tunnels and crypts stay dry. There are puddles or even knee-deep water in some sections that stray beneath the Stojanow River.

Gates. The gates are of sturdy and relatively new construction. Unless otherwise specified, the gates are locked and require a set of thieves' tools and a successful DC 15 Dexterity check to open. The gates may be forced open with a successful DC 15 Strength check. Doing so makes an obscene amount of noise, however.

1. CLOISTER OF KELEMVOR

The first chamber the adventurers enter is the Cloister.

The base of the stairs opens into a large, irregularly-shaped chamber. Stone ledges are carved along most of the walls to serve as tables.

The far wall of this room is covered a huge fresco. The painted tiles portraying people from every race and walk of life, arranged with no sense of perspective or relative scale. The design has suffered heavy damage from water seepage and mildew over the centuries.

The recently deceased can be placed on any of several stone biers for viewing by family members and friends before they are carried deeper into the catacombs for interment.

Anyone who examines the fresco and succeeds at a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check sees it for what it truly is—a century-old map of the catacombs. This is hard to recognize, however, due to the damage and the

lack of any consistent scale.

Areas 1 and 2 are typically as far as non-faithful folk ever come into the catacombs. Typically, only the members of the clergy are permitted beyond this point.

2. FUNERARY BANQUET HALL

Many families hold funeral banquets when their loved ones are interred. Middle class and wealthy families prefer to rent a banquet room in an inn or host the banquet in their homes, but the faithful of Kelemvor don't charge for use of this room (labeled "a" on the map), so it's popular with poorer families in Phlan.

This banquet hall is surprisingly pleasant when considering its location. Many colored lanterns and small incense burners are lit. The long tables are boards lain over a pair of trestles fashioned of wood planks, with benches for seating.

A smaller room in the southern corner of the hall is sealed with a locked iron gate.

What at first appears to be a small room or closet turns out to be reveals a shaft down to another chamber. A set of block and tackle hang from the ceiling of the shaft, and handholds have been chiseled into the wall.

This shaft descends into a chamber (labeled "b" on the map) used by the clergy to prepare bodies for interment. Hanging from the top of the shaft is a set of block and tackle; likely for lowering dead bodies to the chamber below.

From this room, there is a small door on the northeastern corner that leads to area 13. The door is locked but may be opened with the same key that unlocked the gate in area 2a, or with a successful DC 15 Dexterity check using thieves' tools. The gate may be forced open with a successful DC 15 Strength check.

3. FIRST FAMILIES OF PHLAN

These crypts are reserved for the wealthy and the powerful: successful merchants, political leaders, military officers, and their families. They have an almost museum-like quality.

This series of crypts has doorways sealed by locked iron grates. Within you see scenes of normal daily life: richly-dressed people seated around dining tables, or at writing desks, or in luxurious chairs.

All of this would be completely normal, except that all of the participants in the macabre dioramas are the skeletal remains of the affluent—carefully posed and interred among their favorite possessions.

Because of this area's attraction to thieves, every iron grate is double-locked and warded. Doomguide Yovir Glandon has the only keys for the locks. Picking a lock requires a successful DC 15 Dexterity check using a set of thieves' tools.

Opening or attempting to open one of the **locks** with anything other than the proper key sets off a *magic mouth* spell that intones, "Think twice on what you are about to do, friend. Your trespass has been noted." In fact, there is no other alarm and the *magic mouth* spell doesn't alert the faithful of Kelemvor to the break-in.

TREASURE

If the characters decide to break in to the crypts, they can collect 40 gp worth of easily-pocketed jewelry, and another 60 gp worth of bulky, but valuable, clothing from each.

The Kelemvorites, however, notice within a few days should any small items be taken. And as the catacombs have recently been sealed, the adventurers are likely the prime suspects.

The Kelemvorites notice characters trying removing bulky items from the catacombs immediately upon exiting.

Cassyt will inform Doomguide Glandon if she sees any of the adventurers take any of the treasure belonging to the dead.

4. THE BONE PIT

The faithful of Kelemvor don't know why some bones were thrown here while others were stored more respectfully in loculi and orderly ossuaries. In fact, this pit was used long ago by one of the more macabre funerary cults (see area 5).